CURATING HISTORY

1.3 Confederate Memorial Hall New Orleans, Louisiana

Confederate Memorial Hall opened its doors in New Orleans on January 8, 1891. The oldest museum in Louisiana, it celebrates southern heritage and history with a focus on Civil War artifacts from the Confederate Army. In fact, the museum houses one of the largest collections of Confederate memorabilia in the United States, including uniforms and boots, weapons, personal items, and photographs. What challenges and advantages might a museum face in choosing to showcase items from one side of a war rather than from both sides?

Binoculars and Case

These 1863 binoculars and leather case belonged to a Confederate soldier. Cavalry generals—generals who commanded soldiers on horseback—and officers carried binoculars as part of their gear. Confederate soldiers also commonly carried a canteen, blanket roll (similar to a sleeping bag), ammunition and a weapon, and very simple food.



How might binoculars like these have helped officers on the battlefield?

New Yorker William Ketchum designed and patented this Civil War hand grenade.



Ketchum Hand Grenade

Unexploded hand grenades make an interesting addition to any wartime museum exhibit—especially early ones from the Civil War. Confederate and Union soldiers tossed these three- and five-pound hand grenades like darts into enemy territory during battles. The weapons have been recovered from famous battle sites such as Vicksburg and Petersburg.

Copyright 2018 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.



Tintype Portrait

A photographer captured this 1861 tintype portrait of Sergeant Joseph Corneille, a member of the 22nd Louisiana Infantry, in his full dress uniform. Tintypes were invented in the 1850s and involved the transfer of a photograph to a thin sheet of iron coated with enamel. These portraits were prized possessions. They were also expensive. People bought elaborate frames like the one shown here, so they could put their portraits on display. They also carried them in cases or envelopes so the tintypes would be protected.

Many Civil War soldiers in full uniform had a tintype created before they headed off to battle. Why do you think the soldiers wanted to have these portraits created?

Confederate Battle Flag

Many Confederate regiments designed and adopted their own personalized battle flags during the Civil War. The red and white Van Dorn battle flag shown below was used by the regiments under the command of Confederate general Earl Van Dorn in Louisiana, Missouri, Mississippi, and Arkansas between 1862 and 1863. The 13 white stars represent the 13 Confederate States of America.

